

DISTANCE Chapter 02

Kangbin Yim*

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1 The Universe's True Hardware: Energy Gap, Momentum, and Equalization

The Engine of Change: The Energy Gap

If time and space are not the fundamental hardware of the universe, what remains beneath their observational interface?

What actually causes change?

DISTANCE begins with the Energy Gap.

Every observable transformation begins with a difference.

A difference in temperature.

A difference in pressure.

A difference in electrical potential.

A difference in density.

A difference in chemical state.

A difference in relational binding.

Where no difference exists, nothing requires reorganization.

Where a difference exists, the possibility of change appears.

Consider a massive rock resting near the top of a mountain.

To human eyes, the rock appears motionless. Its position remains unchanged. No visible trajectory is being drawn. Nothing seems to happen.

Yet the apparent stillness conceals a profound asymmetry.

The rock, the mountain, the valley, the Earth, and the countless energy islands composing them do not occupy an equivalent relational state. What conventional physics

*email: yim@sch.ac.kr (Prof. SCH University, Korea)

describes as gravitational potential energy represents a difference that has not yet been resolved.

The rock does not remain still because nothing exists.

It remains still while an energy gap remains stored within a relational structure.

If the supporting relationships weaken, fracture, or lose their ability to constrain the unresolved difference, the rock begins to fall.

Observers then describe the event through time, distance, acceleration, and velocity.

They say that the rock moved a certain number of meters during a certain number of seconds.

But none of those scales caused the fall.

Time did not push the rock.

Space did not open a path.

The change began because an energy difference already existed and because the relational conditions that had prevented its resolution could no longer be maintained.

The same principle governs flowing water.

Water descends through a valley not because time advances but because the relationships composing the landscape contain an unresolved energy difference.

A waterfall does not fall because space points downward.

It falls because the energy relationships between its upper and lower states are not equivalent.

When the waterfall erodes stone, disperses spray, transfers heat, and produces sound, science may describe each phenomenon with extraordinary precision.

Yet beneath every measurable effect lies the same condition:

a difference exists,

and the relational structure is being reorganized in response to it.

Energy Gap is therefore not one physical phenomenon among others.

It is the precondition that makes change possible.

But possibility is not yet actuality.

An energy gap may exist without immediately producing observable change.

That distinction leads to the second fundamental concept of DISTANCE.

From Energy Gap to Momentum

An Energy Gap is not identical to Momentum.

This distinction is essential.

An energy gap may remain latent.

Two islands may possess a significant difference between them, yet that difference may not become an effective process of change.

The surrounding relational structure may constrain it.

A larger energy gap may dominate the environment.

Competing momenta may cancel one another.

An existing island may absorb the difference into its internal equilibrium.

The gap exists, but it has not yet become dynamically effective.

Momentum begins when an energy gap crosses the relational threshold required to reorganize the existing structure.

This threshold is not necessarily a fixed numerical boundary.

It depends upon the entire relational environment.

The same energy gap may produce effective momentum in one condition and remain latent in another.

A small difference may become decisive when surrounding constraints weaken.

A large difference may remain suppressed when an even larger relational structure governs the system.

Energy Gap therefore belongs to the domain of potential difference.

Momentum belongs to the domain of effective reorganization.

The distinction may be summarized simply:

Energy Gap makes change possible. Momentum makes change effective.

Momentum is not merely motion in the conventional mechanical sense.

It is the effective tendency through which an unresolved energy difference begins reorganizing relationships.

A chemical reaction expresses momentum.

Heat transfer expresses momentum.

The deformation of a material expresses momentum.

The collapse of a star expresses momentum.

The development of a living organism expresses momentum.

The reorganization of a society expresses momentum.

Their observable forms differ, but their deeper structure is the same.

A difference becomes effective.

Relationships begin to change.

This also clarifies the meaning of apparent stillness.

A system can contain enormous energy gaps while showing little observable change.

Stillness does not prove equality.

It may indicate only that the existing relational structure has not yet allowed the gap to become dominant momentum.

What appears inactive may therefore contain intense unresolved potential.

Conversely, a small gap may generate rapid change if the system offers few constraints against its resolution.

The strength of change cannot be inferred from the size of the energy gap alone.

It must be understood through the relation between the gap, the threshold, and the surrounding momentum structure.

The Boundary of an Island

The distinction between Energy Gap and Momentum also clarifies the boundary of an Island.

An island cannot be defined only by a visible surface.

A cell membrane, the surface of a planet, a national border, or the edge of a galaxy may help an observer identify a structure, but none alone defines its deepest boundary.

The true boundary is dynamical.

Suppose two smaller islands possess an energy gap between them.

Under isolated conditions, that gap might become effective momentum, driving them through a relatively direct process of gap resolution.

They would behave as distinct islands.

But suppose both are embedded within a much larger island whose momentum structure dominates their relation.

The energy gap between the two smaller islands does not disappear.

Yet it may fail to express itself as independent momentum.

From the perspective of the larger relational structure, the two smaller islands behave almost as parts of one island.

Their difference remains latent inside the larger equilibrium.

The boundary between them therefore exists potentially, but not yet effectively.

If the surrounding momentum structure later changes, their previously suppressed energy gap may cross the necessary threshold and become effective momentum.

At that moment, the two structures begin behaving as distinguishable islands within a newly configured relation.

The island boundary is therefore not a permanently fixed line.

It is the threshold at which an energy gap becomes sufficiently effective to generate independent momentum.

This does not mean that island boundaries are arbitrary.

Their exact placement may depend on the scale and purpose of observation, but their underlying principle is not arbitrary.

The principle is dynamical independence.

An island is a relational structure within which momenta are sufficiently coordinated to sustain one coherent pattern of behavior, while differences beyond its effective boundary can generate momentum that reorganizes it as a distinguishable unit.

This definition allows the same concept to operate across scales.

An atom can be an island.

A cell can be an island.

A human body can be an island.

A society, planet, star system, or galaxy can also be an island.

Each contains smaller islands.

Each participates in larger islands.

No scale possesses absolute privilege.

What matters is where momentum becomes effectively independent.

Momentum and Distance

DISTANCE does not treat Momentum and Distance as unrelated ideas.

They describe the same effective relational process from two different perspectives.

Momentum describes the active resolution of a difference.

Distance describes the effective relational separation revealed through that momentum.

This duality must be distinguished from the relation between Energy Gap and Distance.

An energy gap may exist while no effective momentum has yet emerged.

In that condition, the two islands may remain effectively distant despite the presence of a substantial difference.

Energy Gap and Distance therefore do not form a complete duality.

Momentum and Distance do.

When an energy gap becomes effective momentum, the relational separation between the participating islands changes.

A strong momentum means that the relationship has become effective.

The islands are no longer relationally remote.

Their Distance has become shorter.

A weak or unrealized momentum means that the relationship remains ineffective.

Their Distance remains longer.

Distance is therefore not merely geometric separation.

Two islands may be spatially adjacent yet remain relationally distant if no effective momentum connects them.

Two islands may appear spatially remote yet become relationally close if strong momentum continuously links them.

This is why DISTANCE must not be reduced to ordinary physical distance.

It is a measure of effective relational reach.

Momentum and Distance are dual descriptions of this reach.

The same process can be stated in two ways:

an energy gap has become effective momentum,

or

the effective Distance between the islands has shortened.

Likewise, as a specific energy gap is neutralized, the exclusive momentum binding those islands weakens.

Their particular relation becomes less dominant.

The islands then become, on average, more distant from one another as independent relational units and more available to broader relations.

This leads to a second expression of the same universal tendency:

Momentum minimizes particular energy gaps and thereby maximizes average energy distance.

The two expressions are not contradictory.

They describe different levels of the same smoothing process.

At the local level, a particular effective Distance becomes shorter so that momentum exchange can occur.

At the global level, the resolution of that specific energy gap weakens exclusive binding and allows the islands to participate more evenly in wider relational structures.

Thus the universe continually shortens effective Distance where a gap must be resolved

while increasing average Distance by neutralizing privileged and unequal relations.

This local–global duality will later become essential to understanding gravity, rotation, and the apparent tension between centripetal and centrifugal phenomena.

Equalization: Reinterpreting Entropy

To understand the direction of this process, we must reconsider the conventional language of entropy.

Entropy is often introduced through the idea of disorder.

A room becomes messy.

A sandcastle collapses.

A deck of cards loses its original arrangement.

These metaphors may be useful, but they easily encourage a human-centered misunderstanding.

The universe is not attempting to create disorder.

It does not recognize cleanliness, arrangement, usefulness, or chaos.

What observers call disorder is often the visible result of a more fundamental process: the reduction of differences.

DISTANCE therefore interprets entropy as equalization, or more precisely, as smoothing.

Where temperature differs, heat is exchanged.

Where pressure differs, material flows.

Where charge differs, electrical momentum forms.

Where chemical potential differs, reactions proceed.

Where relational energy differs, islands reorganize.

In every case, the system moves toward a condition in which the original difference becomes less effective.

Consider a heated metal plate.

One region is hot, another cold.

The temperature difference generates momentum in the form of heat transfer.

Energy spreads through the internal relationships of the plate.

As the difference decreases, the momentum weakens.

When every region reaches the same temperature, the heat flow ceases.

This final state is often described as maximum entropy.

But nothing about it is necessarily chaotic.

It may be perfectly uniform.

It may be silent.

Its defining feature is not disorder but the absence of an effective difference capable of generating further momentum.

A drop of ink in water reveals the same principle.

At first, the ink is concentrated.

A strong difference exists between the ink-rich region and the surrounding water.

That difference produces effective momentum through diffusion.

The ink spreads.

Its local concentration decreases.

The privileged relation between particular ink particles and their original location weakens.

Eventually, the ink becomes distributed throughout the water.

The visible structure disappears.

The system has not moved toward arbitrary chaos.

It has moved toward a smoother distribution in which the original energy and concentration differences have become less effective.

The energy gap has been minimized.

The average relational Distance has been maximized.

Entropy increase, energy-gap reduction, distance maximization, and smoothing are therefore not separate processes.

They are different descriptions of the same universal tendency.

Local Smoothing and Global Smoothing

Equalization does not proceed in only one direction or at only one scale.

Every island participates simultaneously in local and global smoothing.

Local smoothing occurs within a relational structure.

The internal islands exchange momentum in ways that reduce their mutual energy gaps and preserve a temporary equilibrium.

Global smoothing occurs beyond that local structure.

The same island participates in larger relational environments whose energy differences continue to be redistributed.

These two tendencies may support one another.

They may also compete.

Within a large island, internal momentum may draw smaller islands toward the region where their combined momentum contributions approach an average net value of zero.

That locally preferred region appears as the center.

The center is not fundamentally a geometrical point.

It is the region where the internal momentum structure is most effectively averaged.

At the same time, the smaller islands remain participants in broader global smoothing.

Their relations are not exhausted by the larger island that temporarily contains them.

They continue to form momentum with external structures.

The local tendency seeks equilibrium within the current island.

The global tendency continues the reduction of differences across wider relational scales.

This tension is not an exception.

It is one of the most common conditions in the universe.

Later, the same principle will explain why an island may move toward the center of a larger island while not simply collapsing into it.

The center-directed local momentum appears as gravity or centripetal behavior.

The broader global momentum appears as centrifugal behavior or as the continuing tendency toward wider relational redistribution.

Rotation emerges when neither tendency completely dominates.

It is a temporary optimization between local and global smoothing.

This does not make rotation a different fundamental process.

It remains energy-gap resolution.

But it is a constrained form of resolution in which multiple momenta continuously prevent one another from completing a simple, direct reorganization.

Smoothing Is Not Simple Convergence

The language of equalization can easily create another misunderstanding.

If every energy gap tends to be reduced, does everything simply move toward one point?

Does smoothing mean universal convergence?

No.

Local smoothing and global smoothing must be distinguished.

Within a particular island, energy momenta may converge toward an average-zero region.

This produces a center-directed tendency.

But across the universe as a whole, smoothing does not require all islands to collapse into one geometrical location.

Global smoothing resembles the diffusion of ink through water.

Differences are redistributed across broader relationships.

Specific concentrations weaken.

Exclusive bindings become less dominant.

Average energy density becomes flatter.

From the perspective of ordinary geometry, this may appear as dispersion, expansion, or increasing separation.

From the perspective of DISTANCE, it is the maximization of average energy distance through the minimization of privileged energy gaps.

Thus the same universal process may appear locally as convergence and globally as dispersion.

There is no contradiction.

Locally, momentum moves toward the region where the internal relational imbalance can be averaged most effectively.

Globally, the resolution of local imbalances reduces exclusive binding and enables wider redistribution.

The universe does not simply seek nearness.

Nor does it simply seek separation.

It seeks the smoothing of effective differences.

Nearness and separation are observational consequences that depend upon scale.

The Limit of Perfect Equalization

If smoothing continues, what lies at its ultimate limit?

We can imagine a state in which every effective energy gap has disappeared.

No relationship contains a difference capable of crossing the threshold into momentum.

No momentum remains to reorganize the structure.

No effective Distance becomes shorter or longer because no relation changes.

In such a state, the concepts of time and space would lose their operational meaning.

Time is observed through the intensity of momentum resolution.

If no momentum is resolved, there is no relational intensity from which temporal change can be interpreted.

Space is observed through the complexity of momentum-resolution relationships.

If no effective momentum relationships remain, there is no changing relational complexity from which spatial scale can be interpreted.

From an impossible external viewpoint, such a state might appear both infinitely extended and completely undifferentiated.

Every distinction would have vanished.

It could be described as one ultimate island because no effective boundary would remain within it.

But this state would not be a fertile beginning.

It would be the end of every possible change.

A completely dead universe could not awaken itself.

If no difference exists, no new momentum can emerge.

If no distinguishable relation remains, no internal mechanism can create one.

This suggests that perfect equalization may function as a logical limit rather than a state the living universe can actually reach or leave behind.

For a universe to change, at least two distinguishable relational states must remain.

Difference is not a flaw accidentally introduced into reality.

It is the condition that allows reality to remain active.

The universe lives because smoothing is incomplete.

Energy gaps remain.

Thresholds are crossed.

Momentum continues to form.

Islands separate, combine, rotate, dissolve, and reappear.

The destination of smoothing may be perfect flatness, but the universe we observe is the process that exists because that destination has not been reached.

The Hardware Beneath Spacetime

The true hardware of the universe is therefore not time and space.

But neither are time and space meaningless.

They remain valid observational scales through which the deeper process becomes measurable.

Beneath them lies a more fundamental sequence:

relationships contain energy gaps;

energy gaps may remain latent or cross a threshold;

effective gaps become momentum;
momentum reorganizes relationships;
that reorganization changes effective Distance;
and the continuous reduction of relational imbalance appears as equalization, entropy increase, motion, and cosmic evolution.

This sequence must not be read as a rigid temporal chronology.

The universe does not first create a gap, then wait, then generate momentum according to an external clock.

The sequence is conceptual.

It identifies different aspects of one relational process.

Energy Gap explains the possibility of change.

Threshold explains when that possibility becomes effective.

Momentum explains the active reorganization.

Distance explains the effective relational state.

Smoothing explains the universal direction of the process.

Time and space appear when observers translate the intensity and complexity of that process into measurable scales.

The hardware is relational.

The engine is difference.

The effective action is momentum.

The universal direction is smoothing.

Everything that follows—mass, gravity, inertia, linear motion, rotation, life, and civilization—must emerge from this same structure.

If DISTANCE is to offer a coherent interpretation of the universe, it cannot invoke a new fundamental cause whenever the scale changes.

The same principle must remain valid everywhere.

A falling stone.

A rotating planet.

A living cell.

A competing society.

A transforming civilization.

Each must be understood as a different expression of energy gaps becoming effective momentum within relational structures that continually move toward smoothing.

The universe does not change because time flows.

Time becomes meaningful because the universe changes.

The universe does not reorganize because space exists.

Space becomes meaningful because relational complexity must be observed.

Beneath both lies the true hardware:

Energy Gap, Momentum, Distance, and the unending process of Equalization.